

STACK OVERFLOW AND BUILDING AN ANSWER ARCHIVE

Stack Overflow is a popular website for answering programming questions, but many new programmers express frustration, or even intimidation, about using it. Stack Overflow moderators have a reputation for ruthlessly closing questions that don't meet their strict guidelines. But there's a good reason that Stack Overflow runs such a tight ship.

Stack Overflow isn't intended to answer questions so much as to build an archive of programming questions matched with their answers. Accordingly, they want questions that are specific, unique, and not opinion based. Questions need to be detailed and well stated so search engine users can easily find them. (The internet for programmers before Stack Overflow is the basis for the joke in the "Wisdom of the Ancients" XKCD comic at <https://xkcd.com/979/>.) Thirty entries for the same question not only would duplicate the answering efforts of the site's volunteer experts, but could confuse search engine users with multiple results. Questions need to have concrete, objective answers: "What is the best programming language?" is a matter of opinion and can cause needless argument. (Besides, we already know that Python is the best programming language.)

But being in the position of needing and requesting help only to have your question promptly closed can be hurtful and embarrassing. My advice is to first carefully read the advice in this chapter and on Stack Overflow's "How do I ask a good question?" guide at <https://stackoverflow.com/help/how-to-ask/>. Second, feel free to use a pseudonym if you're afraid of asking "dumb" questions. Stack Overflow doesn't require real names for its accounts. If you prefer a more casual place for your questions, consider posting them to <https://reddit.com/r/learnpython/>, which is more lax about which questions they accept. Still, be sure to read their posting guidelines before submitting a question.

Make Your Code Readable with Proper Formatting

The point of sharing your code is so your helper can run your program and reproduce the error you're getting. Not only do they need the code, but they also need it properly formatted. Make sure that they can easily copy your source and run it as is. If you're copying and pasting your source code in an email, be aware that many email clients might remove the indentation, resulting in code that looks like this:

```
def knuts(self, value):
if not isinstance(value, int) or value < 0:
raise WizCoinException('knuts attr must be a positive int')
self._knuts = value
```
